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Summer 2025 Internship Reflection

1.

I spent Summer 2025 interning at Cisco as a finance analyst intern. I've had this role since the summer of 2023, working full-time during summers and part-time during academic years. Our team manages and forecasts quarterly operating expenses for the company's "Common Hardware Group" department. This summer, I worked approximately 520 hours (40 hours per week times 13 weeks). I would summarize the work I did during this period in three points:

1. Enhancing our team's foreseeability into millions of dollars of quarter-end accrued expenses by collecting bottom-up accrual estimates at the purchase order level
2. Learning Excel VBA and applying my learnings to internal datasets to find highest spending engineers/program managers for accrual inquiries; managing monthly collection of accrual data
3. Using Power BI to design and map an expense forecast dashboard template for presentation to department engineering leaders, providing insights into projected expenses by various dimensions

2.

During the summer, I learned technical skills, Cisco's financial policies, and general lessons about the business/corporate world. During less busy periods, I took it upon myself to learn Excel VBA, Python, Tableau, and Power BI. This helped me sharpen my data processing and analytical skills, and I was able to apply my learnings to internal financial data (as mentioned in points two and three in question one). Continuing to learn Cisco's financial reporting procedures and forecasting methods was also very insightful into general corporate policies I may see at other companies. I also learned the importance of clear communication during cross-functional work. In order to collect the financial data our team needed from engineers and program managers, I have to phrase inquiries in ways they would understand (many of them are not familiar with financial reporting terminology, policy, and procedure).

3.

The biggest surprise to me was how much room for improvement there is for our organization in terms of using the latest technology and tools to improve procedures. Individuals in our organization are just now starting to implement GenAI into their work, while us students have been exposed to it for a couple of years now. I'm also working on implementing Power BI into our team's processes to visualize spending trends, as well as the relationships between projected expenses, quarter-to-date actuals, and quarterly budget for our organization. Power BI wasn't a tool they were using before, but once our team got a wake-up call from our boss that we need to be contemporary to have a value-add for the organization, I started working towards leveraging it with my team's data. Earlier in my internship, I had assumed that my teammates knew and were following best practices, but this summer taught me that we are all continuing to

learn as time goes on, technology evolves, and the company changes.

4.

My experience from this internship has positioned me as a contemporary corporate finance candidate who can work cross-functionally with other types of employees. The work I've done with Excel, AI, Power BI, Python, and more has drastically reinforced my technical skills in the latest tools and my ability to apply them to financial data. I've worked with extremely large financial datasets, so the scope of my experience will serve me well and ensure I'm comfortable working with large volumes of data. My extensive experience in obtaining expense data from engineers, as well as my work with Power BI, has taught me how to communicate financial information with non-financial stakeholders. For example, perhaps in a future role, I could use dashboards to visualize revenue trends by product group to communicate to product managers what types of products have been unknowingly increasing in popularity.

5.

Since Cisco is not a B2C retail company with brick-and-mortar stores, and my team has no involvement with revenue or sales, I haven't been able to make many observations regarding entertainment, matching, pricing, or convenience. Out of the EMPAC aspects, I can best speak to assortment. Cisco seems to have been making an effort to expand the breadth of its portfolio, exemplified by its recent acquisition of Splunk within the past couple of years. Overall, they seem to have a very wide breadth of products, ranging from networking to IoT products, as well as security products/services. Therefore, I wouldn't classify them as a specialty company. Cisco's

product assortment is continuously changing, as engineers are constantly working on better products and technology continues to evolve.